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Search Committee
Department of Economics
University of Maryland, College Park
College Park, MD 20742
USA

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to express my interest in the tenure-track Assistant Professor position in Economics at the University of Maryland, College Park, beginning Fall 2026. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at Johns Hopkins University, advised by Professors Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis, and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My research fields are macroeconomics, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on understanding the determinants of wealth inequality and the mechanisms through which heterogeneity in returns to wealth shapes aggregate outcomes. In my job-market paper, I estimate the degree of heterogeneity in individual portfolio returns using micro-data from the Survey of Consumer Finances and simulate a structural model in which households face idiosyncratic return risk. I show that allowing for persistent heterogeneity in returns substantially improves the model's ability to match the empirical distribution of wealth, offering a tractable way to connect micro-level return dispersion to macroeconomic inequality.

In a second project, I use the Health and Retirement Study to examine the relationship between interpersonal trust and portfolio performance. Building on the literature that finds a hump-shaped relationship between trust and income, I show that a similar relationship holds for individual returns to wealth measured in the HRS data, highlighting a behavioral channel through which social attitudes shape saving and investment outcomes. This work also provides new estimates of the persistent component of returns to net worth, which motivate the calibration of heterogeneity in my structural model.

The University of Maryland's Department of Economics is a research-intensive department with strong strengths in macroeconomics, international economics, and quantitative methods. My empirical and computational skill set, combined with my interest in distributional macroeconomics and household finance, align well with the department's mission. I am especially excited about the proximity to Washington, D.C., which opens unique opportunities for engaging policy-relevant research and interdisciplinary collaboration.

Teaching. My teaching experience centers on undergraduate macroeconomics and an upper-level macro policy seminar, where I have led weekly discussion sections and held regular office hours for classes ranging from 16 to 40 students. My approach is student-centered: I aim to help students "convince themselves" that they have moved from confusion to understanding by holding structured office-hour coaching that builds trust and confidence. At Maryland I am prepared to teach *Principles*

of Macroeconomics, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory, Money and Banking, and Quantitative Methods for Economics. I would also welcome developing electives such as *Economics of Inequality and Tax Policy* or *Computational Macroeconomics and Policy*, emphasizing reproducible workflows and evidence-based decision-making.

I believe I would be a strong fit because my computational and empirical toolkit allows me to (i) produce robust, data-backed estimates of returns and distributional outcomes, (ii) build and validate models that speak to macroeconomic and policy-relevant questions, and (iii) collaborate across teams to translate insights into actionable formats for diverse audiences. I am enthusiastic about joining the University of Maryland's Department of Economics and contributing to its teaching, research, and service missions.

I would be honored to join your faculty and to mentor students pursuing quantitative careers in economics. Thank you for your consideration; I welcome the opportunity to discuss my fit with your department at your convenience.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards